Rajan, Mukund Rajan, Madhu Kannan, Harish Bhat and Nirmalya Kumar) ranged between forty-five and fifty-five; their average age was less than the average working experience of the veterans in Ratan's GEC.

R. Mukundan, the MD of Tata Chemicals, comments, '[Ratan] Tata's team had legends who could mentor anyone.' Their 'sheer weight of experience' gave them 'wisdom beyond compare' and 'brought to bear a combined wisdom'. 'Wisdom with experience is more sustainable,' he underlines.

Consequently, the veterans of the large group companies 'bridled at the suggestions made by the [new] GEC and TBEM members'. They never took the GEC members seriously and ended up making light of the council's views and recommendations. The management of these giant companies 'often saw little reason to take advice from a group of people who had little practical experience of running companies', wrote a leading newsmagazine. Commenting on the council, Subedar says that the coterie around Mistry 'was a concern', the GEC members were 'definitely not the best', and their 'style of management was different from the Tatas'.

About the GEC under Mistry, Chandrasekaran says, 'All of them were very inexperienced … Each one of them became a centre of power.' In the same breath, he adds, 'You cannot ignore the veterans.' What disappointed him more was that Mistry used the GEC members as go-betweens—they would talk to the senior leadership of operating companies on his behalf. 'He should have talked directly,' Chandrasekaran opines.

Mukundan has a similar opinion. He says that Ratan would call all the CEOs and MDs directly (as Chandrasekaran now does too). Mistry never did that and always had a GEC member sitting in on all his meetings, he recalls.

Another issue that increased the divide between Mistry and Ratan pertained to Tata Docomo. The problem related to the fulfilment of certain contractual obligations by Tata Teleservices Ltd (TTSL), which had tied up with NTT Docomo of Japan in 2008. It ended up becoming a clash of approaches based on the importance each party accorded to being ethically correct.

The Japanese company had invested $2.2 billion for a stake of around 26 per cent in the Indian entity, on the back of an agreement that stipulated performance targets. It also had an exit provision which guaranteed 50 per